

Lab: How Yarn Speaks Through Touch

Materials Exploration — Perception

Objective

Develop your perceptual awareness of yarn by systematically exploring how different fibers communicate through touch, sight, and sound. You will practice active sensing, discover your prediction errors, and map your own perceptual generative model.

Materials Needed

- 6-8 yarn samples of varied fiber types, weights, and textures (including at least one variegated yarn)
- A crochet hook appropriate for each yarn
- A blindfold or opaque bag
- Paper bags numbered 1-8 (to hide yarn identities)
- A notebook for observations
- A friend or fellow crafter (optional but recommended)

Part 1: Perception Without Prediction (15 minutes)

Place each yarn sample in a numbered paper bag without looking at it (or have a friend prepare the bags).

For each bag, reach in and handle the yarn without looking: 1. Describe the tactile sensation in detail: smooth or rough? Warm or cool? Springy or limp? Light or heavy? Slippery or grippy? 2. Predict the fiber type, weight category, and color. 3. Rate your confidence for each prediction (1-5). 4. Open the bag and compare your predictions to reality.

Record your results:

Bag #	Tactile Description	Predicted Fiber	Actual Fiber	Predicted Weight	Actual Weight	Predicted Color	Actual Color	Confidence

Reflection: Where was your prediction error highest? What surprised you? Which sensory channels were most informative?

Part 2: Detecting Surprise (15 minutes)

1. Take a smooth, uniform yarn and crochet 10 rows of single crochet.
2. While working, have a friend secretly tie a small knot in the yarn about 2 feet ahead of your hook (or prepare this yourself beforehand and forget the exact location).
3. Continue crocheting and note the exact moment you detect the knot.
4. Record: Did you feel it before you saw it? How far in advance? What was the sensation?
5. Repeat with a textured or boucle yarn. Compare how easily you detect the knot in each.

Reflection: The knot is a prediction error — a deviation from the expected smooth signal. Compare how surprise feels in smooth versus textured yarn.

Part 3: Multimodal Perception with Variegated Yarn (20 minutes)

1. Choose a variegated or self-striping yarn.
2. Crochet 20 rows, paying attention to the color pattern as it develops.
3. After 10 rows, pause and predict:
4. What color will appear in the next 5 stitches?
5. Will the colors pool, stripe, or create argyle-like patterns?
6. Continue and check your predictions.
7. Change your stitch count per row (add or remove 3 stitches) and observe how the color pattern shifts.

Reflection: Your growing ability to predict the color pattern is your generative model updating in real time. How quickly did you start to anticipate the color repeats?

Part 4: The Sound of Crochet (10 minutes)

1. Work 5 rows with a crisp cotton yarn. Listen to the sound of the hook and yarn.
2. Work 5 rows with a soft wool. Listen again.
3. Work 5 rows with an acrylic. Listen.
4. Can you hear differences? Describe the sounds each material makes.

Reflection: Sound is an often-overlooked perceptual channel in crochet. Some crafters report that they can hear when their tension changes or when a yarn has a flaw. Is sound part of your perceptual model?

Discussion Questions

1. Which of your senses provided the most accurate information about yarn identity — touch, sight, or something else?
2. Were there cases where your prediction was wrong in a way that taught you something new about a fiber?
3. How did working with the variegated yarn change your relationship between tactile and visual attention?

Reflection

Write a short paragraph about how yarn "speaks" to you. Before this lab, were you aware of how much perceptual processing happens while you crochet? What new aspects of perception did this lab reveal?